

A and S Tier AI Certificates

This covers the A and S tier certificates from an Instagram reel that ranks seven AI certifications S to D by hiring value. The reel gave no links or written detail. It only offered them to people who commented "CERTIFICATE" on the post. Everything below comes from each provider's own pages.

Where the tiers come from: the tier board shown on screen and the spoken narration agree for all seven certificates. S tier is Claude Certified Architect and Generative AI with Large Language Models. A tier is Google AI Essentials.

On the name: the auto-transcript heard "Cloud Certified Architect". The caption and the badge shown in the reel both read "Claude Certified Architect", and the badge border reads "ANTHROPIC CERTIFIED". It is a real Anthropic credential, confirmed against Anthropic's own exam guide. It is not a cloud-architect certificate from AWS, Azure or Google Cloud. The badge in the reel is the **Foundations** level.

Comparison table

Certificate	Provider	Tier in reel	Cost	Time to complete	Format	Official link
Claude Certified Architect - Foundations	Anthropic	S	\$125 exam fee. Prep courses are free. Registration needs a partner-company email.	No official prep-hours figure. Exam is 120 minutes.	Proctored exam via Pearson VUE (online or test center)	Registration page (https://anthropic-partners.skilljar.com/claude-certified-architect-foundations-certification)
Generative AI with Large Language Models	DeepLearning.AI + AWS, on Coursera	S	Certificate is paid. Exact price not shown on the provider page (unverified). Free audit not confirmed.	Page says "2 weeks at 10 hours a week". Weekly breakdown adds up to about 17 hours.	Self-paced online: videos, 3 quizzes, 3 AWS labs	Coursera course page (https://www.coursera.org/learn/generative-ai-with-llms)

Certificate	Provider	Tier in reel	Cost	Time to complete	Format	Official link
Google AI Essentials	Google, on Coursera	A	No free audit. \$49/month after a 7-day free trial (US/Canada).	Page says "4 hours". Its module times add up to about 8 hours.	Self-paced online, 5-course specialization	Coursera page (https://www.coursera.org/learn/google-ai-essentials)

Claude Certified Architect - Foundations (S tier)

What it is and who it is for. A proctored technical exam from Anthropic. It is one of four credentials in the Claude Certification Program, which runs through the Claude Partner Network. It tests tradeoff decisions when building real systems with Claude: the Claude API, the Claude Agent SDK, Claude Code and Model Context Protocol (MCP). The exam guide describes the target candidate as a solution architect with 6+ months of hands-on experience with Claude APIs, the Agent SDK, Claude Code and MCP.

Read this before paying. Registration requires a partner-organization email on a recognized company domain. Anthropic's FAQ says "Certification is open to organizations in the Claude Partner Network" and "personal email addresses will not work." It is not open to the general public with a personal email today. You would need to work for, or join, a company in the Claude Partner Network.

How to get it:

1. Your organization joins the Claude Partner Network (the partner application is linked from the Partner Academy at claude.com/partners). You then get a partner-domain login to the [Anthropic Partner Academy](https://anthropic-partners.skilljar.com/page/partner-certifications) (<https://anthropic-partners.skilljar.com/page/partner-certifications>).
2. Open the [Architect - Foundations certification page](https://anthropic-partners.skilljar.com/claude-certified-architect-foundations-certification) (<https://anthropic-partners.skilljar.com/claude-certified-architect-foundations-certification>). Read the [exam guide](https://everpath-course-content.s3-accelerate.amazonaws.com/instructor%2F6nizmqk8tpzpfjvt6qmmav7rh%2Fpublic%2F1783542750%2FClaude+Certified+Architect+%E2%80%93+Foundations+Exam+Guide.pdf) (<https://everpath-course-content.s3-accelerate.amazonaws.com/instructor%2F6nizmqk8tpzpfjvt6qmmav7rh%2Fpublic%2F1783542750%2FClaude+Certified+Architect+%E2%80%93+Foundations+Exam+Guide.pdf>) and the exam policy.
3. Register and pay at checkout.
4. Use the confirmation email to create a [Pearson VUE](https://www.pearsonvue.com/us/en/anthropic.html) (<https://www.pearsonvue.com/us/en/anthropic.html>) account and book a session.
5. Choose online proctoring (OnVUE) or a Pearson VUE test center.
6. On exam day, have a valid government photo ID that matches your registration name exactly. Online, your webcam stays on throughout. You accept a confidentiality agreement before starting.
7. The exam: 120 minutes, 60 multiple-choice and multiple-response items, 4 scenarios drawn from a published bank of 6. Pass mark is a scaled 720 out of 1,000. English only.
8. If you pass, the credential is valid for 12 months. (Badge delivery appears to be through Credly, based on a Credly help link on the FAQ page. Not confirmed.)

9. Renew before 12 months with a free, non-proctored assessment on the Partner Academy. If it lapses, you pay and sit the full exam again.

Time. Anthropic publishes no prep-hours estimate. The exam guide gives a "How to Prepare" checklist instead: build an agent with the Agent SDK, configure Claude Code for a real project, design and test MCP tools, build a structured-extraction pipeline. The exam takes 120 minutes, about 135 with check-in and the post-exam survey.

Cost.

- Foundations exam fee: \$125 USD. Never free for a non-discounted candidate.
- Partner discounts: Select and Preferred partners get 50% off. Global Premier partners pay nothing through December 31, 2026.
- Retakes cost the full fee each time. Waits: 14 days after a first fail, 30 after a second, 90 after a third. Maximum 4 attempts per rolling 12 months.
- Cancelling or rescheduling within 24 hours of the exam, or not showing up, forfeits the fee.
- Renewal after 12 months is free.
- Free to learn: the official prep courses (<https://anthropic-partners.skilljar.com/page/claude-certified-architect-foundations-prep-courses>) (AI Fluency, Building with the Claude API, Claude Code in Action, Claude 101, Introduction to MCP, Claude on Google Cloud, Claude with Amazon Bedrock) cost nothing. They do not grant the certification.
- Unverified: one third-party article claims non-partners can sit the exam for \$99. Anthropic's own FAQ says a partner email is required to register, so treat that claim as likely wrong.

Higher level. There is also a Claude Certified Architect - Professional exam at \$175 USD. Its format, length and pass mark were not checked.

Where it can be taken. Anthropic does not publish a full country list. Online proctoring is not available with IDs from Belarus, Cuba, North Korea, Russia, Syria or restricted regions of Ukraine. Pearson has suspended all exam delivery for residents of Iran.

Prerequisites. No required course or earlier exam. Must be 18+ with government ID, and must have a partner-organization email to register.

Generative AI with Large Language Models (S tier)

What it is and who it is for. A course by DeepLearning.AI and AWS, on Coursera. It covers the LLM project lifecycle: scoping a use case, choosing a model, pre-training basics, fine-tuning (including parameter-efficient fine-tuning), evaluating LLMs, reinforcement learning from human feedback (RLHF) and deploying LLM applications. Intermediate level. Built for developers, not complete beginners. Rated 4.8/5 from about 3,650 reviews.

How to get it:

1. Go to the Coursera course page (<https://www.coursera.org/learn/generative-ai-with-llms>) and click "Enroll now".
2. Sign in or create a Coursera account.

3. Choose the paid certificate option. A free "Full Course, No Certificate" option may or may not be offered. The page only says some courses "may" offer it.
4. Complete the 3 weekly modules: all 3 graded quizzes (about 60 minutes each) and all 3 hands-on labs, which run on AWS through Vocareum.
5. When everything is passed, Coursera issues the certificate. It can be added to LinkedIn.

Time. The page headline says "Flexible schedule, 2 weeks at 10 hours a week". Its weekly breakdown says 6, 5 and 6 hours, about 17 hours total. Self-paced.

Cost.

- Certificate: paid. The page says you need to "purchase the Certificate experience" to earn a certificate. The exact price is loaded at checkout and was not visible on the provider page. **Unverified:** third-party pricing roundups put single Coursera course certificates at \$49-99, and Coursera Plus (which covers many courses) at \$399/year. Check the checkout page before paying.
- Free to learn: not confirmed. A free audit option and a free trial are both mentioned as possibilities, but neither is confirmed for this course, and the trial length is not stated.
- Financial aid: Coursera offers it "in select learning programs". Not confirmed for this course.

Prerequisites. Some Python coding experience, plus basic machine learning ideas: supervised vs. unsupervised learning, loss functions, train/validation/test splits. DeepLearning.AI's Machine Learning or Deep Learning Specialization is recommended, not required. More detail on [DeepLearning.AI's course page](https://www.deeplearning.ai/courses/generative-ai-with-llms/) (<https://www.deeplearning.ai/courses/generative-ai-with-llms/>).

Google AI Essentials (A tier)

What it is and who it is for. A beginner, 5-course Coursera specialization from Google. "Zero experience required." For anyone who wants to use AI tools in everyday work. Courses: Introduction to AI (1 hour), Maximize Productivity With AI Tools (2 hours), Discover the Art of Prompting (2 hours), Use AI Responsibly (1 hour), Stay Ahead of the AI Curve (2 hours).

How to get it:

1. Go to the [Coursera page](https://www.coursera.org/learn/google-ai-essentials) (<https://www.coursera.org/learn/google-ai-essentials>) (same product as [Google's certificate page on Coursera](https://www.coursera.org/google-certificates/ai-essentials-google) (<https://www.coursera.org/google-certificates/ai-essentials-google>)) and click "Enroll for Free". This starts a 7-day free trial.
2. Sign in or create a Coursera account.
3. Complete every graded activity in all 5 courses.
4. Google issues the certificate. It can be shared on LinkedIn.
5. If you have not finished and cancelled within 7 days, Coursera starts charging \$49/month until you cancel.

Time. The page headline says "4 hours to complete". Its own module times add up to about 8 hours. Self-paced.

Cost.

- Free audit: none. The page says: "No, you cannot take this course for free."

- Certificate: part of Coursera's subscription. "In the U.S. and Canada, Coursera charges \$49 per month after the initial 7-day free trial period." Prices may differ in other countries. Also included in Coursera Plus.
- Free route: the 7-day trial. About 8 hours of self-paced content fits in 7 days. **Unverified:** the page does not say whether a certificate earned during the trial is kept after you cancel.
- Financial aid: a link to apply appears on the description page where it is offered.
- No free version outside Coursera was found. Google's own page (<https://grow.google/ai-essentials/>) sends you to the same paid Coursera product.

Prerequisites. None.

Which one first

The reel says the best path depends on whether you are an engineer, an entrepreneur or starting from scratch, but it does not say which certificate goes with which path. Based on each provider's own description:

- **Engineer:** Generative AI with Large Language Models. It assumes Python and basic ML and goes into fine-tuning, evaluation and deployment.
- **Entrepreneur or non-technical:** Google AI Essentials. No background needed, a few hours of work, focused on using AI tools at work.
- **Starting from scratch:** Google AI Essentials. The caption says one certificate on the list is "built exactly for you" without naming it. Of the three, this is the only one aimed at beginners.
- **Claude Certified Architect:** the most technical of the three, but you cannot register without a partner-company email. Not a first step for most people.